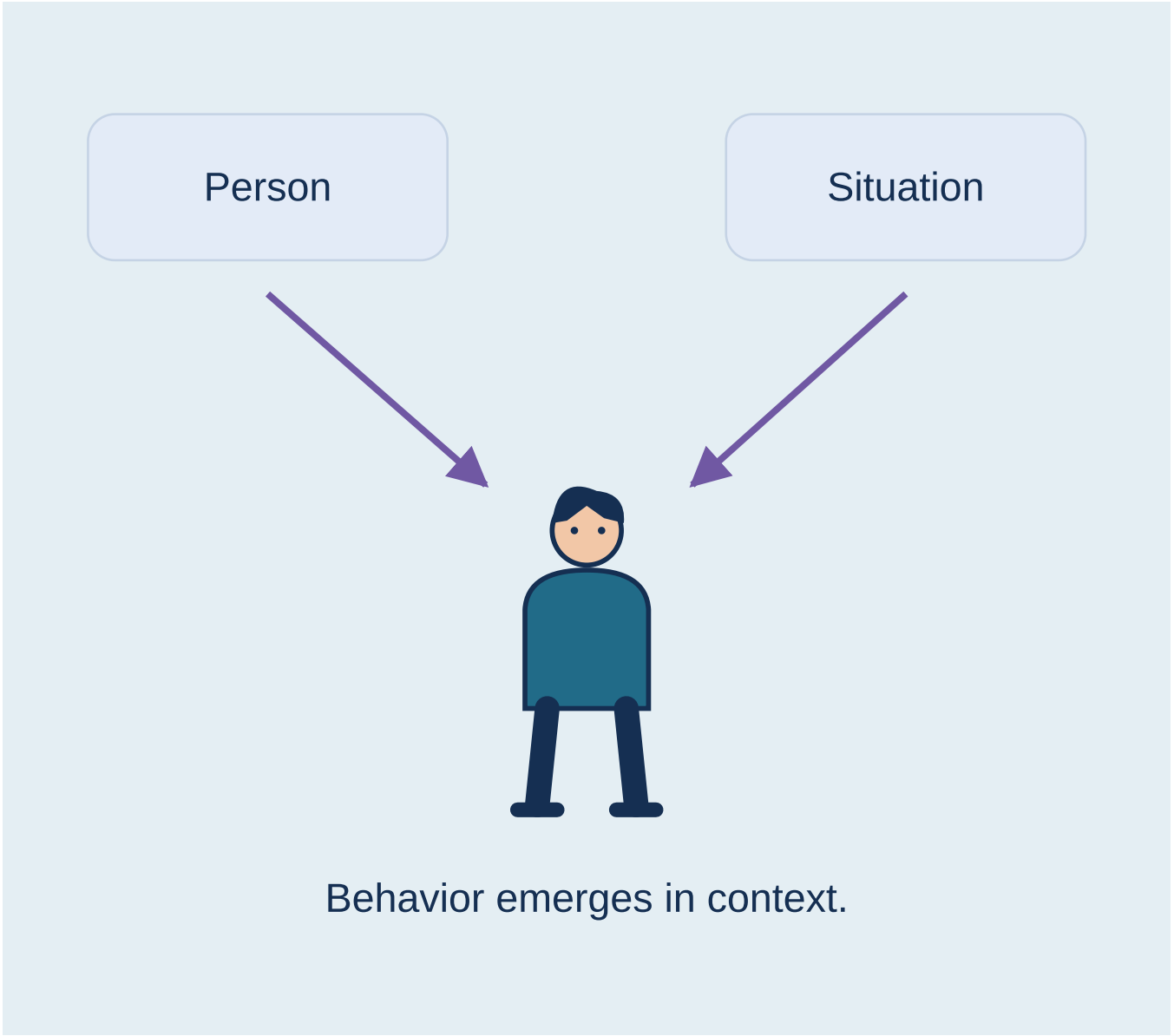
Common Ground
Visual companion

Explore every teaching concept through original diagrams and fictional café examples. Each caption explains the idea and its limits.

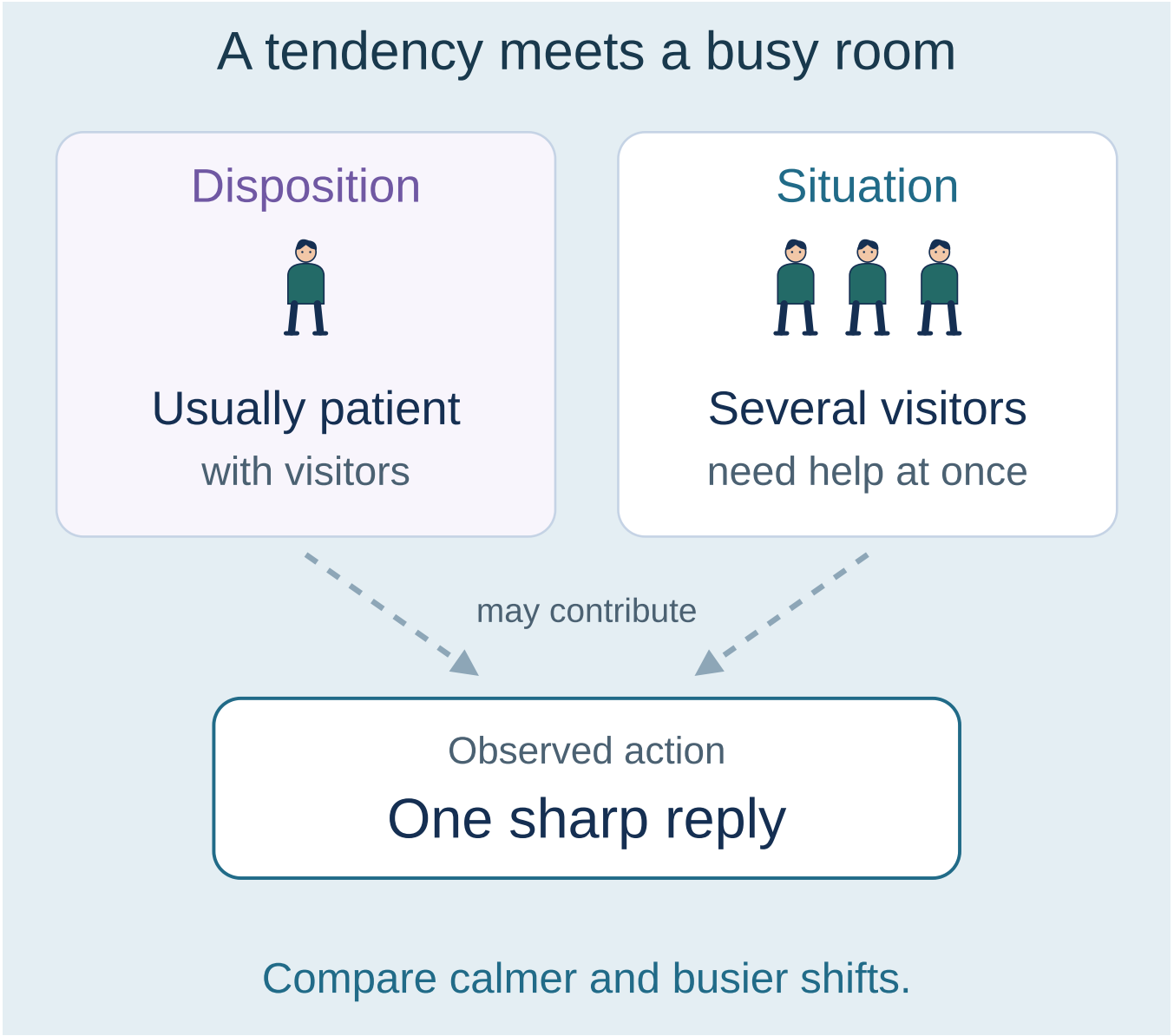
48 visual explanations across ten chapters. Each teaching page has its own primary figure and narration. This companion brings the figures together for reading and printing.

Person, disposition, and situation



A disposition is one personal quality; circumstances also contribute.

Disposition under changing demands



A hypothetical interaction of a disposition and a situation. Dashed paths indicate possible contributions.

Observation and attribution

Two different questions

Observation



Maya arrived after the start.

A recorded action

Attribution



“She doesn’t care.”

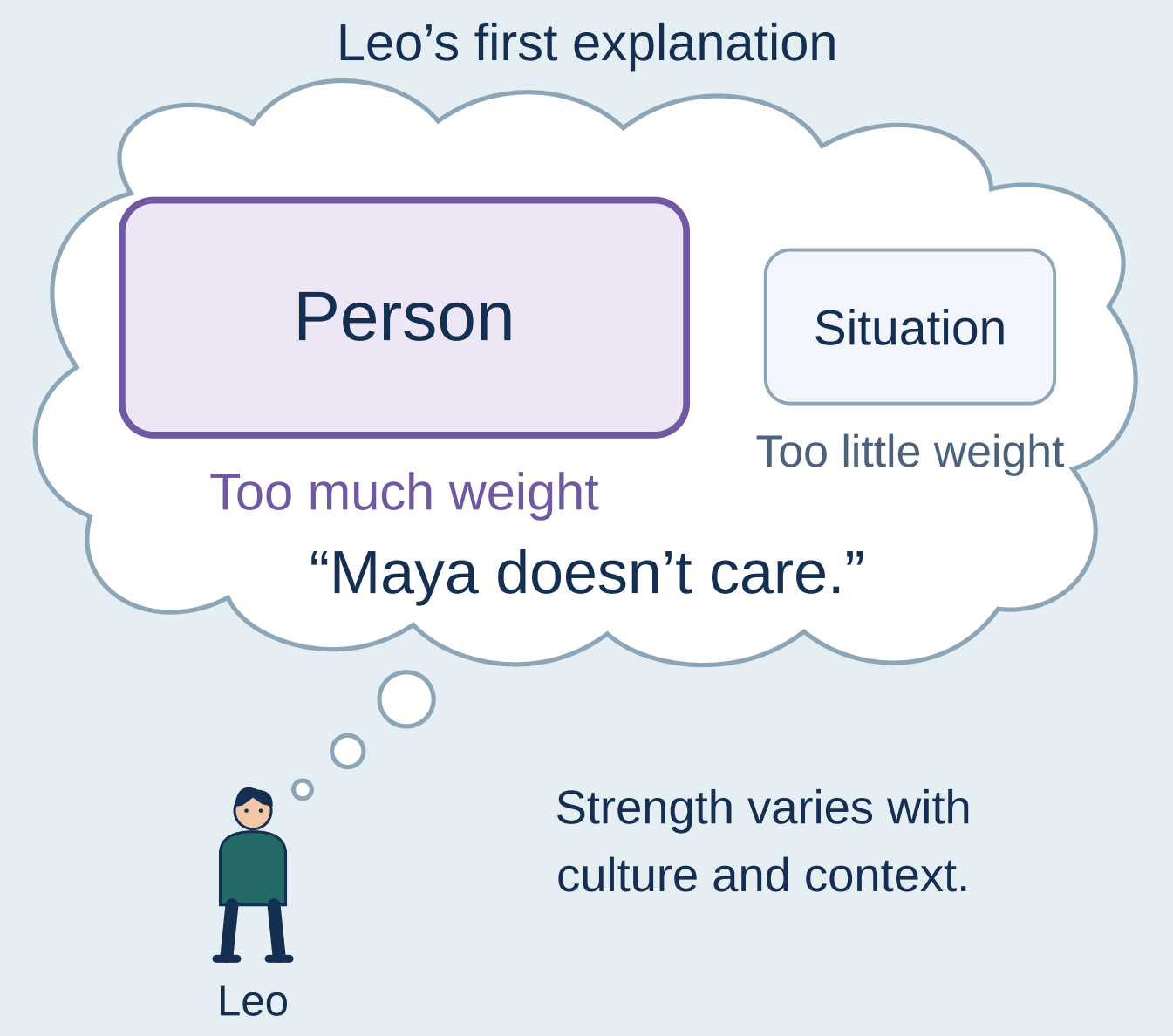
A proposed cause

One statement records an action.
The other proposes a cause.

What evidence could test Leo’s cause?

Leo’s observation and his attribution answer different questions.

Fundamental attribution error



Leo gives personal qualities more weight than the circumstances.

Attribution and actor–observer differences

One observer, two explanations

Leo explains himself



“The bus was delayed.”
Circumstances

Leo explains Maya



“She doesn’t care.”
A personal tendency
Could he be missing her circumstances?

A possible actor–observer difference.
The pattern depends on judgment and setting.

Hypothetical explanations by the same observer.

Test an explanation against evidence

Follow the evidence

Leo’s proposed cause

“She doesn’t care.”

1

Describe the action

Maya arrived after the start.

Keep the cause open.

2

Compare occasions

Is lateness usual across shifts?

Look for exceptions.

3

Check alternatives

Could a travel barrier explain it?

Ask Maya about the delay.

4

Revise your confidence

Weigh the evidence for each cause.

Allow your explanation to change.

Let evidence change your confidence.

Describe, compare, check, and revise. Apply the same steps to your own interpretations.

Correlation and causation

Together does not establish because

Observed pattern



Poster changed.
Attendance rose.
Two things varied together.

Possible explanations

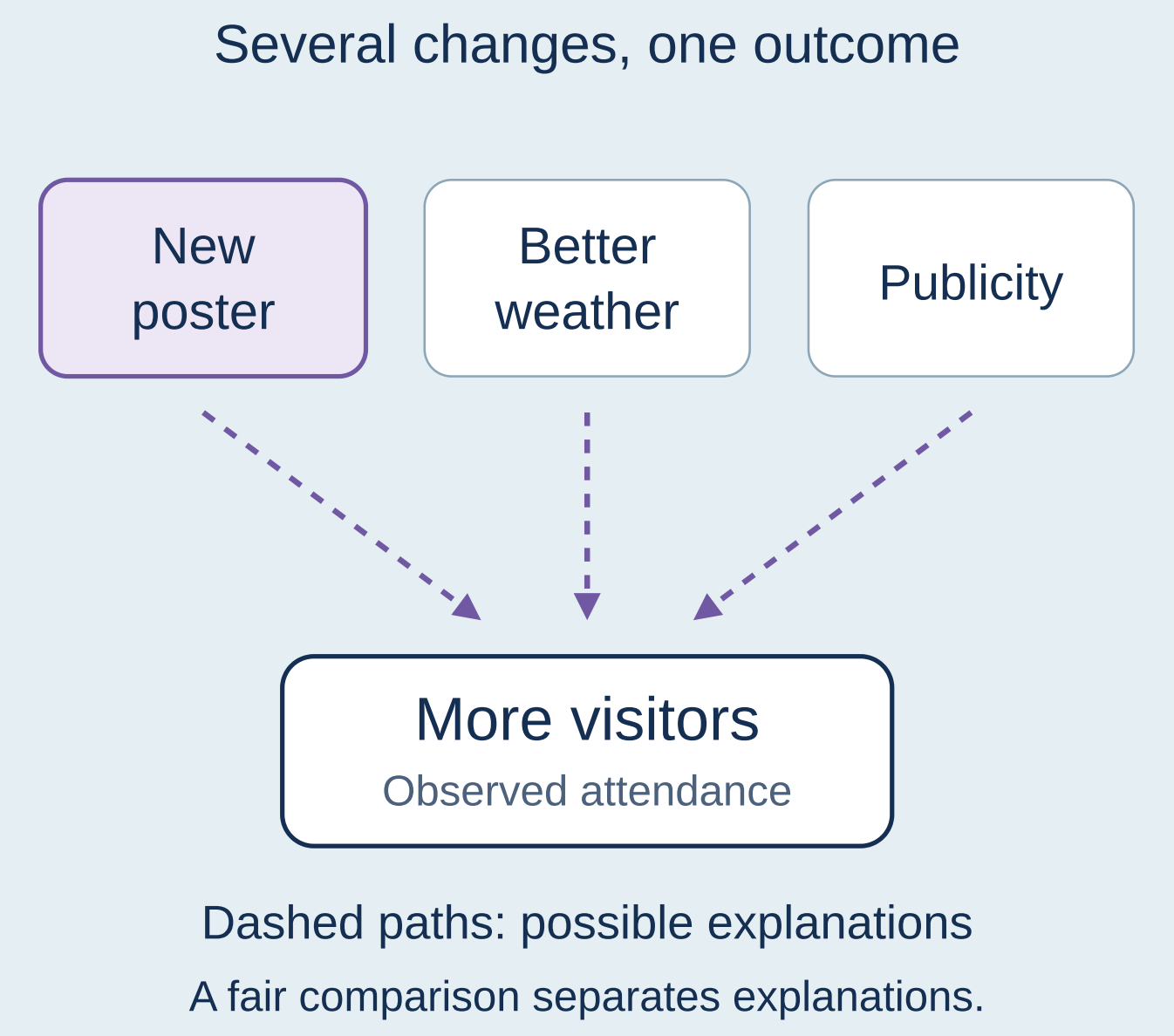


Poster?
Weather?
Publicity?
What would separate these explanations?

Correlation describes a relationship.
A causal claim needs a fairer test.

A shared pattern leaves multiple causes possible.

Confounding



Several changes can fit the same before-and-after pattern.

Random sampling and random assignment

A possible selection-and-allocation design

1. **Population**
   Residents we want to learn about
2. **Random sampling**
   Select people by chance
3. **Sample enters the comparison**
   Who was actually included?
4. **Random assignment**
   Allocate invitation A or B by chance

Assignment does not make a sample representative.

Choosing the sample and assigning conditions answer different questions.

Effect size and uncertainty

Invented attendance example

Invitation A



12 of 100 households attend

Invitation B



15 of 100 households attend

15% − 12% = 3 percentage points

A different sample could give a different estimate.

Invented counts illustrate the size of a difference.

Statistical significance and practical importance

Two questions about a result

Statistical significance



How unusual under a specified model? Often a model of no group difference.

Practical importance



How large is the difference? Is it useful enough for the decision?

Significance does not measure usefulness.
Nonsignificance does not prove zero effect.

Model-based evidence and practical value are different questions.

Preregistration, transparency, and replication

Build confidence through checks

1. **Preregister**
   Record the plan before results
2. **Run a sound comparison**
   Sample size can improve precision
3. **Share methods and materials**
   Make the work inspectable
4. **Replicate independently**
   Check how dependable the finding is

A larger sample cannot fix a biased comparison.

Plan, inspect, and independently repeat a sound comparison.

Availability heuristic, base rates, and denominators

A failure rate needs the whole record

“That toaster failed again!”

Invented record: all comparable repairs

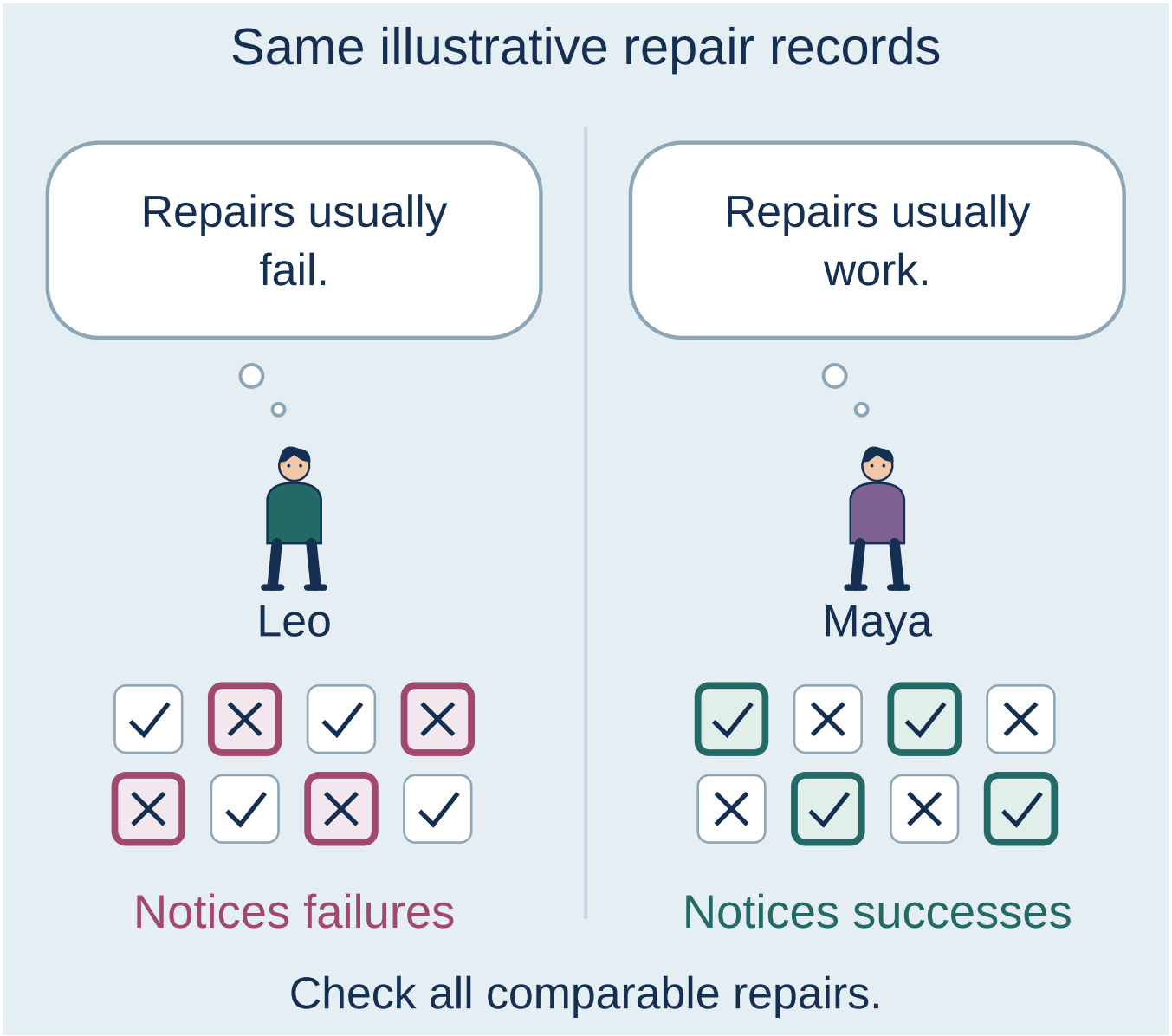


4 failures / 40 repairs = 10%

Availability is a shortcut, not a frequency count.

The invented whole record gives a vivid case its denominator.

Confirmation bias



Expectations can change which evidence gets attention.

Motivated reasoning

A desired conclusion can shape reasoning

1. **Maya wants the café to succeed**
   “I hope our repairs are working.”
2. **Reassuring stories feel persuasive**
   Returns get less attention
3. **Maya can use one test for all cases**
   Define failure and follow up consistently
4. **Maya can invite a challenging review**
   What could change her first belief?

A wanted conclusion can still be correct.

Maya’s desired outcome may shape how she judges the evidence.

Check a bias claim against evidence

Checking someone else’s estimate

Possible distortion



Vivid cases get too much attention. The record does not support the initial estimate.

Possible expertise

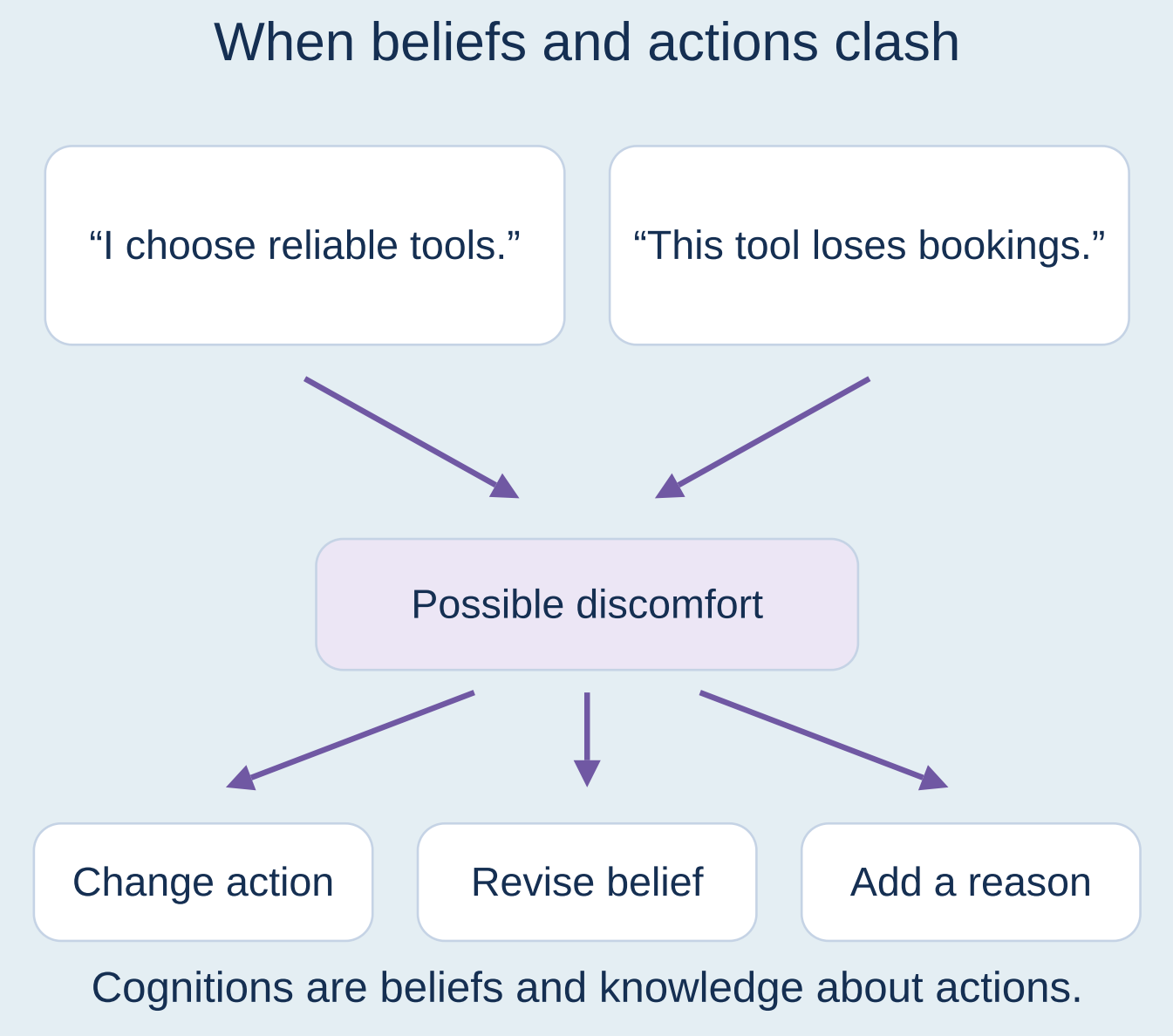


Remembered cases reflect experience. A representative record supports the estimate.

Compare their estimate with a relevant record. Ask which cases they considered.

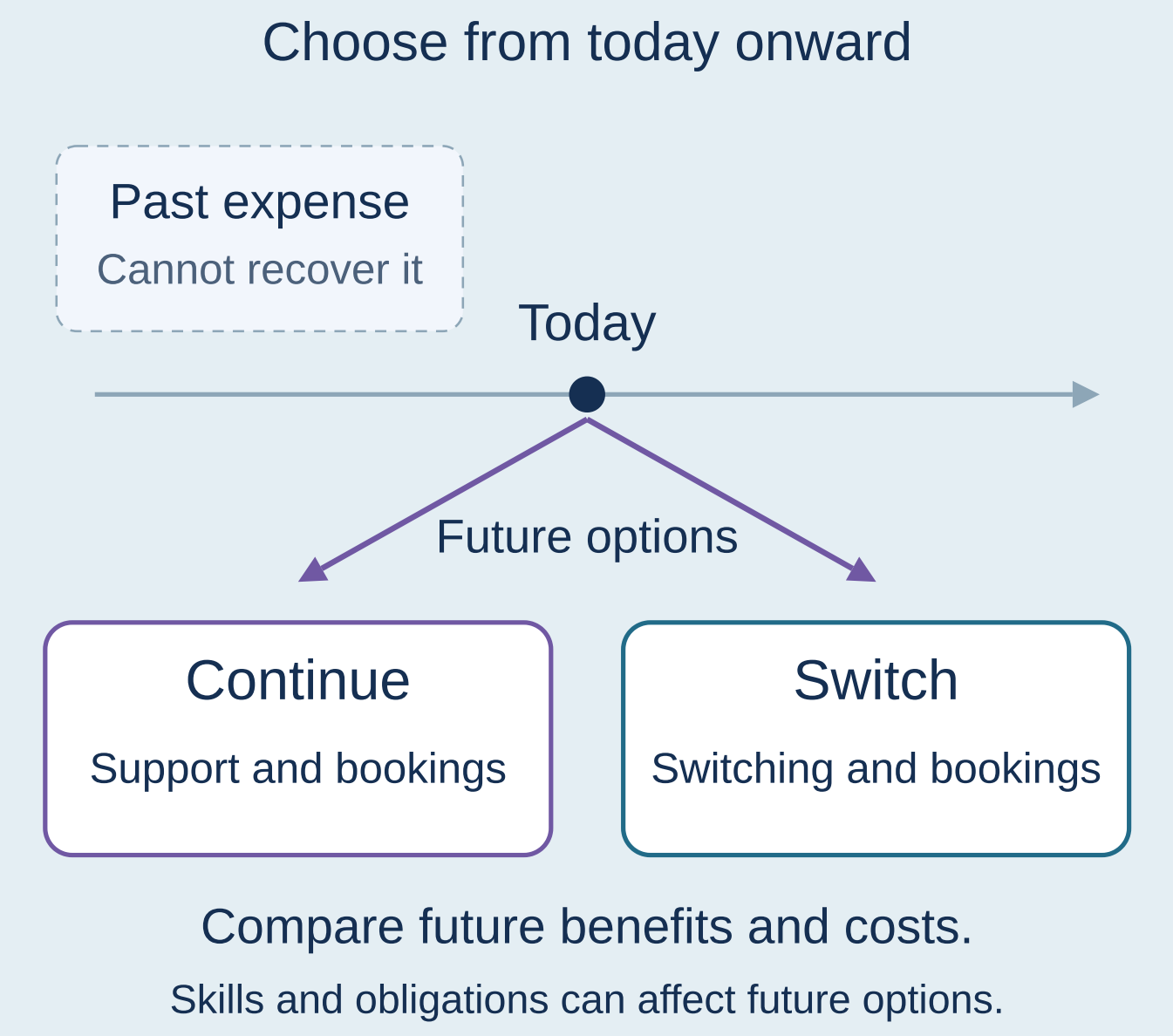
Compare another person’s estimate with the record behind it.

Cognitive dissonance and cognitions



Inconsistency can motivate several different responses.

Sunk cost effect and future consequences



Past spending is unrecoverable; compare future consequences.

A procedure, a prediction, and a theory

A tested prediction and a broader theory

Specific procedure



Argue for a position you do not hold. More or less choice. Primary difference was not supported.

Broader framework



Inconsistency can motivate change or justification. Other predictions need their own tests.

The 2024 replication tests a particular procedure. Its result does not settle every dissonance claim.

The cited replication concerns a particular induced-compliance procedure.

Informational influence and normative influence



The same public agreement can reflect different private reasons.

Compliance and obedience

A request and an authority’s order

Compliance



Leo asks Sam: “Cover my shift?” Sam agrees to the request.

Obedience



The chair instructs: “Skip the check.” The authority role can add pressure.

An authority’s request can involve both. People can question or resist.

Authority can add pressure; it does not make resistance impossible.

Questioning an unsafe instruction

Make questioning practically possible

1. **A required check is bypassed**
   Notice the concern
2. **Pause the unsafe work**
   Use an agreed stop rule
3. **Raise the concern**
   Use the agreed escalation route
4. **Review before proceeding**
   Relevant training and responsibilities

An instruction does not remove accountability.

An agreed route makes a concern actionable.

Classic studies in context

Different tasks, specific pressures

Asch’s task



Compare line lengths after a majority gives incorrect answers. Some people resist.

Milgram’s task



An experimenter urges continuation. Participants believe another person receives shocks.

Methods, ethics, and conditions matter.
These are not universal obedience rates.

Task, setting, ethics, and variation limit generalization.

Attitudes and action

An attitude is an evaluation

Possible evaluation



“Volunteering is worthwhile.” Reasons and values shape the judgment.

A different question

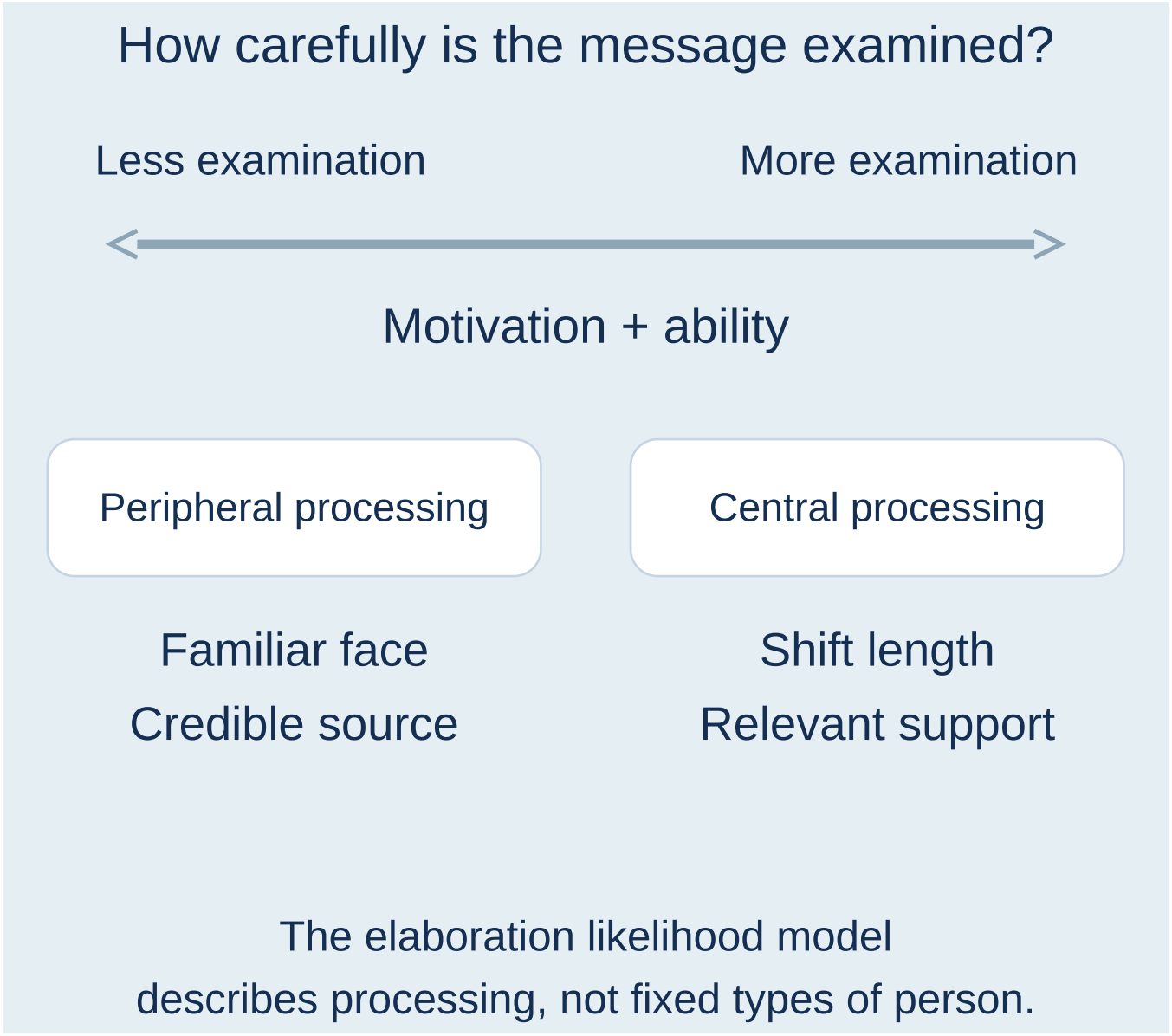


Will I sign up? Time, transport, support, and choice also affect action.

A positive attitude does not guarantee action.
Ask what outcome the message needs to support.

An evaluation and an action are related but distinct.

Central and peripheral processing



The same person can process different messages more or less carefully.

Descriptive and injunctive norms

What happens and what is approved

Descriptive norm



“Many residents volunteer.”
A claim about what people do.

Injunctive norm



“Our community values volunteering.”
A claim about what people approve.

These are example claims; check their truth.
Highlighting low participation can normalize it.

Behavior and approval are different claims; both need evidence.

An honest, usable invitation

Help someone make an informed choice

1. **A relevant reason**
   What would this contribution achieve?
2. **A concrete commitment**
   Time, effort, and available support
3. **An easy next step**
   Ask questions or try a supported shift
4. **Room to decline**
   Measure understanding and informed choice

Remove unsupported claims about what others do.

Support understanding and preserve meaningful choice.

Attention, understanding, and participation

Measure the outcome that matters

1. **Attention**
   An invitation gets a click
2. **Understanding**
   The person knows the commitment
3. **Informed sign-up**
   Participation is freely chosen
4. **Continued participation**
   Check experience and retention

A click alone does not establish these later outcomes.

Measure later outcomes rather than assuming them from clicks.

Social identity and in-group favoritism

Who counts as “our team”?

Repair volunteers



“Give our team first choice of shifts.” Group membership can shape preference.

Welcome volunteers



Their contribution can be overlooked. Favoritism can create unequal access without explicit hatred.

Check workload, incentives, and decision power. A shared name alone does not change those.

Group preference can produce unequal treatment.

A shared goal and workable arrangements

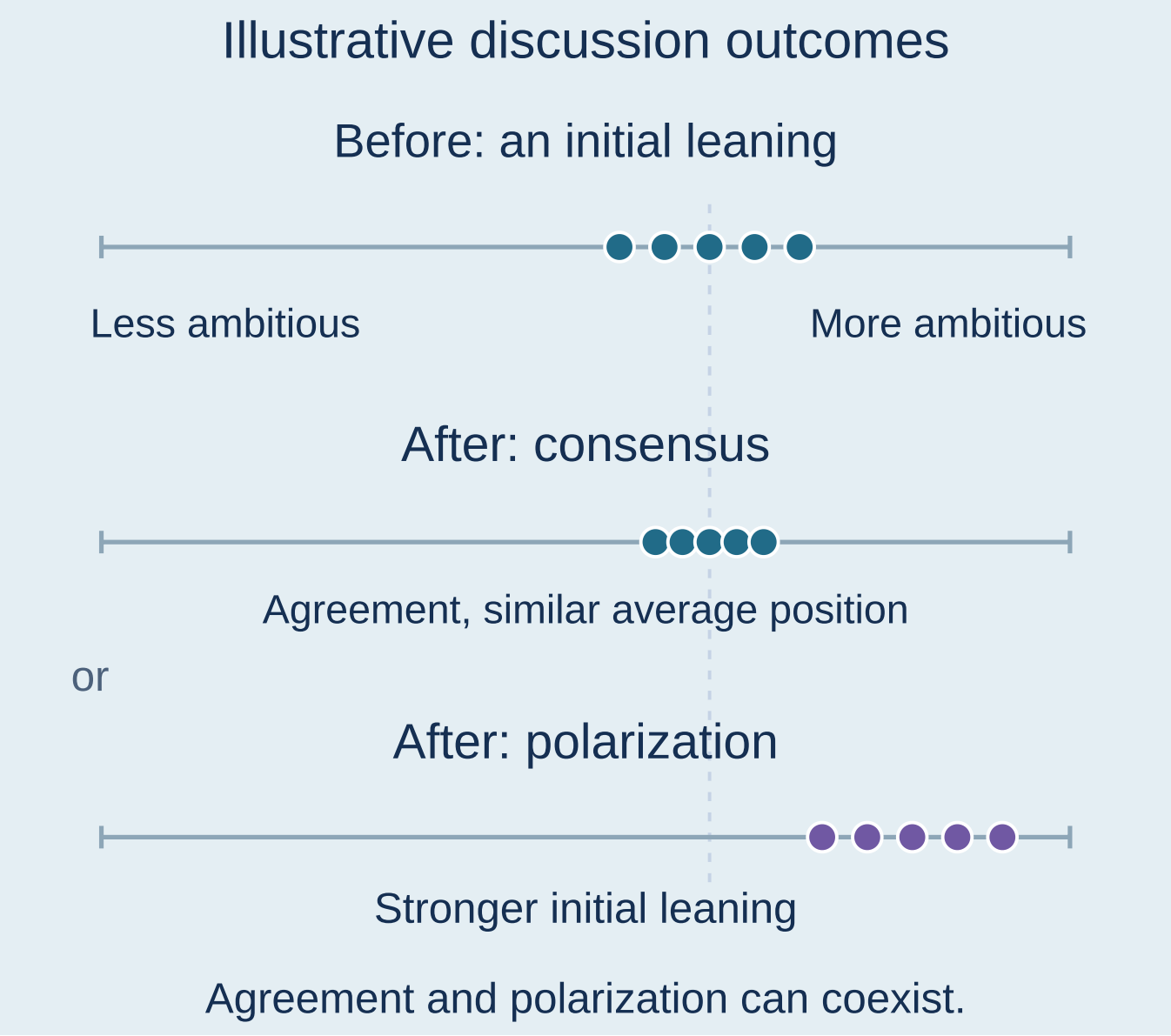
One visitor experience needs both teams

1. **Welcome the visitor**
   Understand the need
2. **Plan the repair**
   Agree roles and resources
3. **Coordinate the handover**
   Tools, timing, and information
4. **Review the visitor experience**
   Share credit, burdens, and decisions

A shared goal needs workable arrangements.

Shared identity needs coordination, resources, and decision rights.

Group polarization and consensus



Agreement can form with or without a more extreme leaning.

Social loafing and coordination loss

Similar poor output, different processes

Social loafing



Individual effort
falls in pooled work.
“My contribution
will go unnoticed.”
A possible process.

Coordination loss



Effort can be high.
Work is duplicated.
A needed tool
arrives too late.
Tasks do not align.

An unfinished task alone does not identify either.
Check effort, tools, sequencing, and roles.

Different processes require different remedies.

Groupthink and visible decision processes

Agreement can hide unspoken doubts

1. **Pressure for agreement**
   Relevant concerns remain unspoken
2. **Examine the actual process**
   Whose information was missed?
3. **Collect independent views**
   Make contrary evidence discussable
4. **Review the decision**
   Clear roles and structured disagreement

A poor decision alone does not establish groupthink.

Ask members about their concerns and check which information reached the discussion.

Stereotypes, prejudice, and discrimination

Three related, distinct concepts

Stereotype: a group belief

“Every newcomer lacks repair skills.”

Prejudice: an attitude

“I dislike newcomers before meeting them.”

Discrimination: unequal treatment

Reject someone for being a newcomer.

These need not form an inevitable sequence.

Belief, attitude, and action are related but distinct.

Rules and unequal access

A welcoming intention can leave barriers

1. **Recruit through existing friends**
   Who never hears about the opportunity?
2. **Require personally owned tools**
   Who lacks the resources to enter?
3. **Meet during working hours**
   Who cannot attend?
4. **Inspect the process and outcomes**
   Intentions alone cannot establish fairness

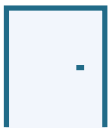
Rules can favor an existing group.

An arrangement can exclude without an openly hostile statement.

Intergroup contact and participation

Sharing a room and sharing participation

Limited participation



Newcomers watch.
Established members control the tools and decisions.

Cooperative contact



Work on a shared goal.
Share relevant tools and decision-making.
Organizers support equal participation.

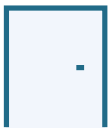
Intergroup contact can help under some conditions.
Check actual access and participation.

Cooperation, equal status, shared goals, and support matter.

Procedural changes to access

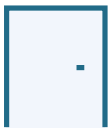
Change the barrier in the process

Existing rule



Apply through existing friends. Bring your own specialist tools.

A proposed change



Open the application. Use relevant criteria. Provide shared tools where feasible. Track participation.

A friendly encounter alone leaves the rule intact. Use follow-up and protect privacy.

Examine who can enter and participate after the change.

Explicit attitudes, implicit associations, and behavior

Different measures answer different questions

Explicit attitude

What someone reports directly

Implicit association

An indirect response pattern in a task

Behavior and access

Who can apply, progress, and participate?

No single score is a complete character diagnosis.

Different measurements do not supply a complete character diagnosis.

Proximity and similarity

A shared shift creates opportunities

1. **Sam and Leo meet on Thursdays**
   Proximity changes who becomes familiar
2. **They discover an interest in radios**
   Similarity can support conversation
3. **They choose further conversation**
   Look for reciprocal interest
4. **Either person can set a boundary**
   Contact creates no right to friendship

Connection is possible, not guaranteed.

Shared settings create opportunities, with mutual willingness.

The mere exposure effect

Repeated encounters can have different effects

Possible familiarity



A face becomes more comfortable to see.
Liking may increase.

A different response



Unwanted contact can intensify annoyance or threat.
More is not automatically better.

The mere exposure effect depends on conditions.
A stated boundary still matters.

Familiarity has limits and does not override boundaries.

Disclosure, responsiveness, and reciprocity

Closeness depends on the response

1. **Leo discloses something personal**
   “It has been a difficult week.”
2. **Sam listens and checks understanding**
   “Have I understood what you mean?”
3. **Sam asks what support Leo wants**
   Listening, practical help, or advice?
4. **Reciprocity over time**
   Mutual consideration, not matching secrets

Disclosure needs willingness and responsiveness.

Connection depends on what each person wants and how the other responds.

Attachment labels and stated boundaries

A declined invitation is useful information

What Sam says



“I need time alone.”
An expressed preference for now.

Leo’s response



Accept the refusal.
Leave future contact optional.
One occasion does not establish an attachment style.

Attachment labels describe studied patterns.
They are not diagnoses or permission to persist.

Leo can respect Sam’s preference without inferring an attachment style.

Relationship evidence and its limits

An association and an individual relationship

Study reports



Some partners report greater similarity and satisfaction. Self-reports can have limitations.

Sam and Leo’s situation

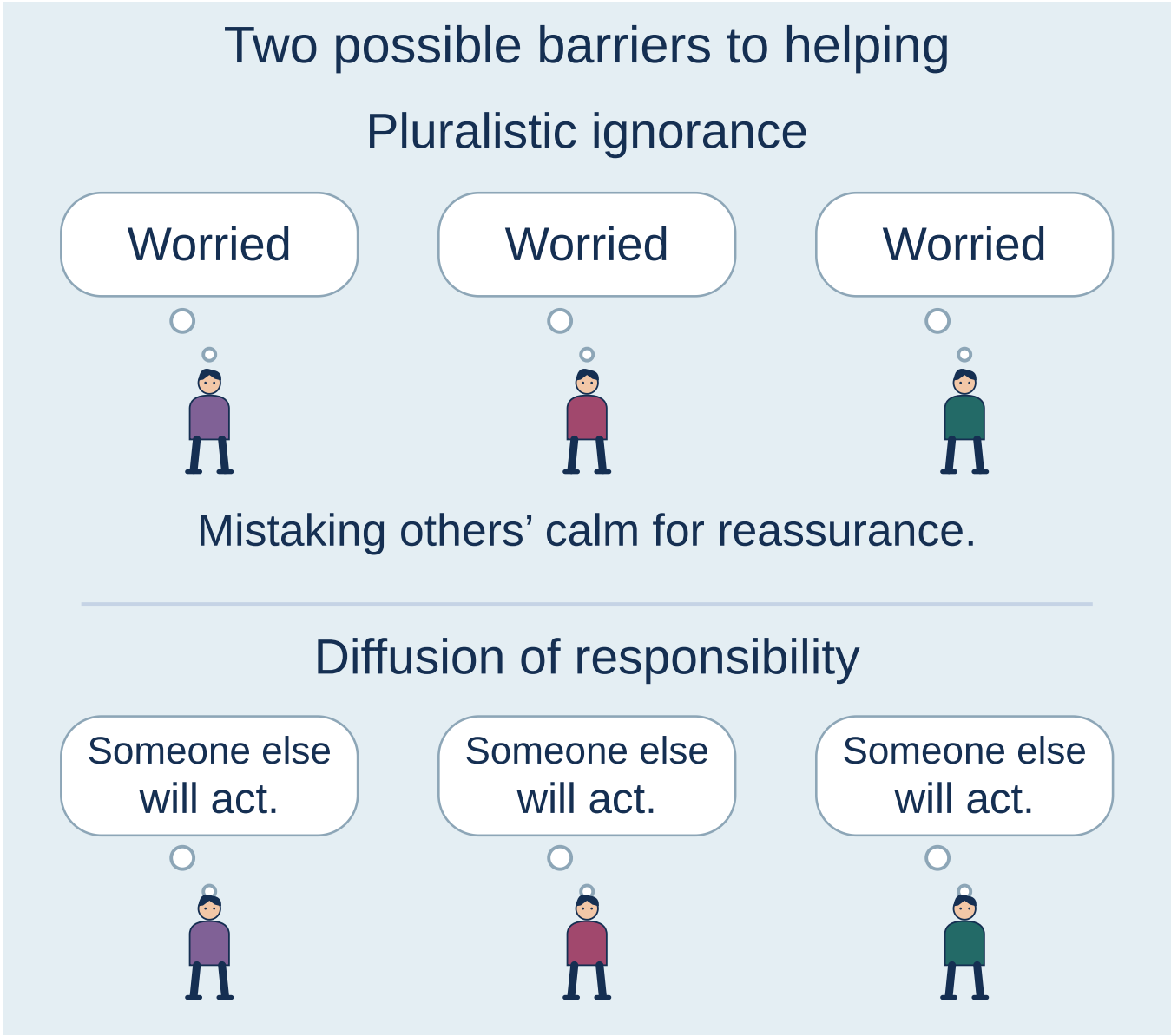


Ask Sam and Leo about their experiences and preferences. A group average cannot choose their goals.

Association alone does not establish an intervention. Ask about the pair’s actual experience.

Use research to frame questions, then ask about Sam and Leo’s own experiences and preferences.

Helping and the bystander effect



In some settings, others' presence can reduce an individual's likelihood of helping. These are two possible processes; context, skills, and support also matter.

A safe helping process

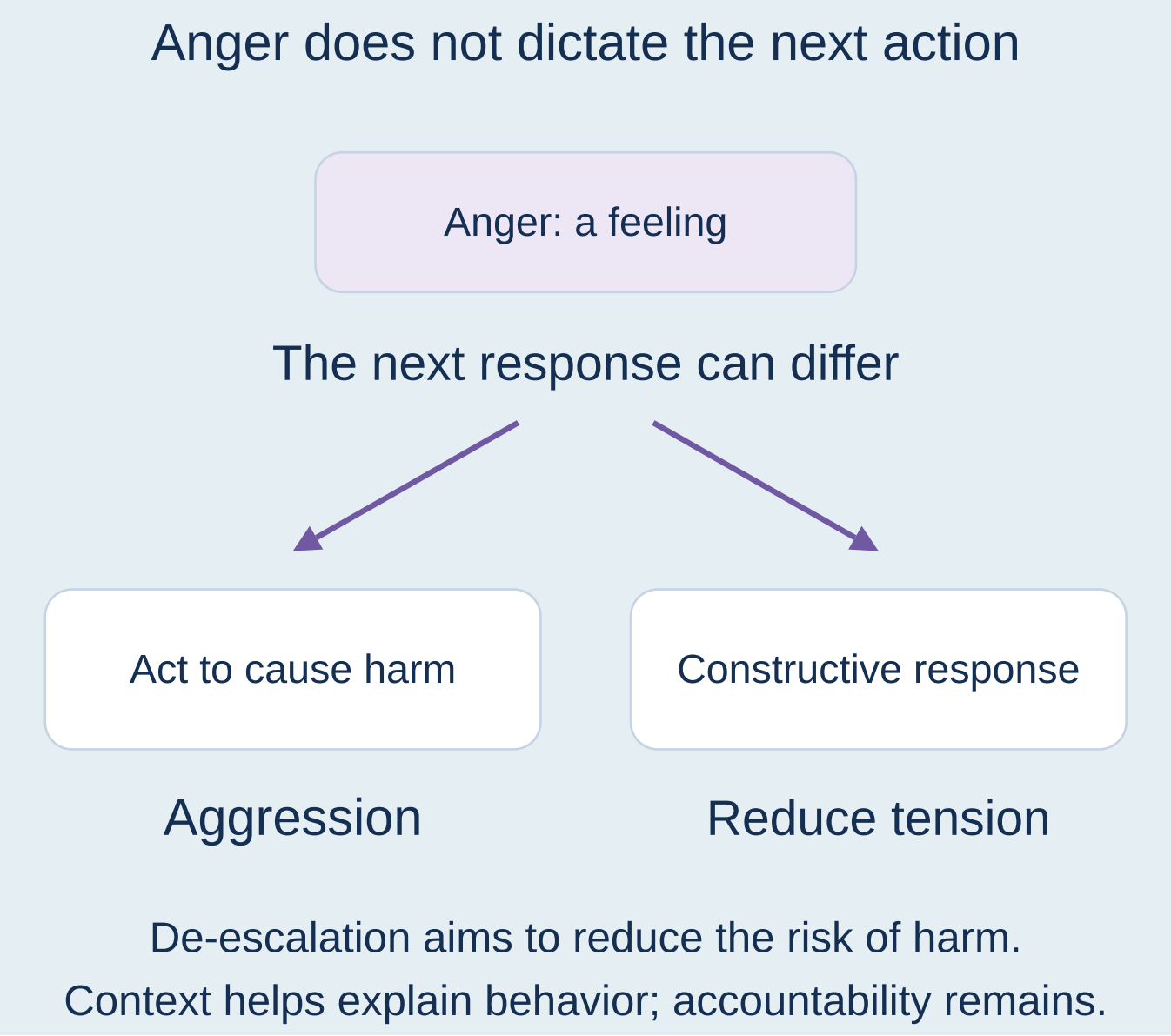
Turn concern into a safe path to action

1. **Notice and interpret the need**
   Clarify what is happening
2. **Accept responsibility**
   Agree who will take the next step
3. **Identify an appropriate safe action**
   Use available skills, training, and support
4. **Act and review**
   For a low-risk task, check the outcome

In emergencies, follow local guidance and training.

Clear responsibility, skills, and support can make action feasible.

Anger, aggression, and de-escalation



A feeling does not predetermine a harmful action.

Cooperation with roles and feedback

Make a shared task workable

1. **A clear shared outcome**
   What needs to be done?
2. **Named roles and resources**
   Who owns each step and has support?
3. **A route for reporting problems**
   What happens if the plan becomes unsafe?
4. **Feedback and a fair division**
   Review contributions, benefits, and burdens

For example, name who checks the replacement shelf.

A specific arrangement can turn a shared aim into coordinated work.

Research measures, context, and safe help

A research measure and a real-world decision

Controlled measure



An unpleasant-noise task measures one laboratory response. It is an imperfect proxy for serious violence.

Real-world context



Danger, relationships, training, and support can change what safe help is possible. Crowds can also help.

Interpret the measure within its limits.
A psychology model does not replace training.

Interpret controlled tasks and real incidents with appropriate limits.